Nehru was soon ready to take up Kennedy's offer. He had tried to diversify India's dependence, but, as a former diplomat recently noted, turning to the US "was the only available option for him."[253] Nehru was aware that the government "had been found lacking" and told Krishna Menon that in taking advantage of offers, Delhi "must rather overdo things than underdo them."[254] There was enough political and public support for a request for assistance. On October 29, the cabinet approved a decision to ask for American aid.[255] And Nehru told the US ambassador that India needed American assistance.[256]

The request was not unopposed in the cabinet. Once it became evident, however, that a balancing Soviet option was not feasible, Nehru worked to overcome the hesitation, especially from Krishna Menon (who would soon be removed from his position anyway), by using parliamentary and military opinion. There was some political opposition to US assistance, primarily in the Communist Party (though its members were split on the war). But the government invoked emergency measures to restrict communist propaganda supporting the Sino-Soviet line.[257]

The US commenced delivery of military aid in early November. It also pressed its allies to aid India—Britain, Belgium, Canada, France, and West Germany subsequently contributed to the effort.

Washington furthermore moved to help India on another front—restraining Pakistan. Even before major hostilities, Kennedy had cautioned the Pakistani foreign minister that the communists would threaten not just India but Pakistan. He dismissed the minister's statement that "my enemy's enemy is my friend" and stressed the importance of the free world working together. As the Sino-Indian crisis mounted, the State Department instructed Walter McConaughy, the US ambassador to Pakistan, to warn Ayub against taking any political or military action that would require India to divert focus or forces. Moreover, it wanted Ayub to offer to keep the India-Pakistan border calm while India was engaged in battle with China. When McConaughy balked at being so blunt, Washington asserted that he had to make clear to Pakistani leaders that they do nothing to add to India's problems—and indeed discuss what steps they could take to ease them.[258] Kennedy subsequently informed Ayub of the US intention to help India with its "immediate needs" against China and reiterated the need for Pakistan not to rock the boat with India.[259]